

KF2 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Try me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

We hope that during your training you will develop a daily or weekly routine that includes a review of the week’s teaching and an exploration of the Karis Fellowships tools. You can also further your training by reading the **Expanded Version** or by listening to the playback of this meeting.

Habits are mindfully cultivated, or they are mindlessly accumulated. In KF, we begin the challenging work of cultivating new habits of personal development, and on that journey, we discover ways to make the work easier. You can take a free course for developing new habits at tinyhabits.com.

Karis Fellowships supports members who are in training, but it offers more than an education and a time of sharing. We anticipate gradual improvement in surprising areas as you regularly attend the meetings. Mindfulness and meditation are foundational skills for change. Mindfulness trains us to be aware of ourselves in the present moment. Meditation teaches us to rest in stillness and connect with God. None of this is easy for anyone. Our minds are like young puppies that need to be trained, first to pay attention and then to respond to commands. I wish that our minds were eager for training like the minds of joyful little puppies and children, but unfortunately, we, in our Idol Selves, have learned to cling to old patterns and actively resist new training. So, you will need to carve out some time and make a considerable effort to retrain yourself. I’d like to remind you that Karis Fellowships is only a guide and a support. It’s up to you to change your life.

When we practice our new disciplines, we are rewarded with growing stability and peace. Our goal is to stabilize our lives so that we can redirect our abundant resources toward launching our glorious potential in Christ.

Let’s continue practicing the **3-Minute Breathing Space**.¹ Follow these instructions as I guide you.

We start with **AWARENESS**.

Sit upright and bring yourself into the present moment. Try stretching the crown of your head toward the heavens and your tailbone toward the earth. If you are sitting in a chair, plant the entire soles of your feet on the floor. If possible, close your eyes. Then ask yourself: *What is my experience right now—in thoughts,*

in feelings, and in my body's sensations? Breathe and get to know yourself. (Pause) What is my experience right now—in thoughts, in feelings, and in my body's sensations? Observe and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

At this stage, your mind might be bouncing all over the place like an active and easily distracted puppy. Observe where your thoughts are going and then gently draw them back to connect with your body and your breath. *(Pause)*

Let's move to **GATHERING**.

Redirect your full attention to your breathing—to each in-breath and to each out-breath as they follow one after the other. Your breath functions as an anchor to bring you into the present moment, to help you find stillness, and to tune your awareness. Observe your breathing for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

If your mind is bouncy, you might produce a sound as you breathe to help you focus. Restrict the breath a little in your throat as it passes by. It's like fogging a mirror. Producing a sound might help you focus on the breath during any part of this practice. *(Pause)*

Now we will go to **EXPANDING**.

Expand the field of your awareness around your breathing so that you have a sense of yourself as a composite whole of mind, body, and emotions, including the part of you that observes those things. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Notice how your body moves as you breathe. *(Pause)* Notice your posture and your face. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now pause, and notice how you feel. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Redirect your mind back to the meeting. The **3-Minute Breathing Space** provides a way to step out of automatic pilot mode and away from habitual reactions to events. It helps us to thoughtfully connect with reality in the present moment. The key skill in practicing a breathing space is to maintain awareness in the present moment without judging who you are or what you are experiencing.

I hope that you have begun your own daily practice of this technique. Any athlete or musician knows that a skill is only useful if you practice it regularly. Regular practice makes the skill available to you in the crush or crisis of the moment. The skill won't be there if you don't practice it. Train yourself in mindfulness with the **3-Minute Breathing Space** in the morning and again later in the day.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Let's continue to explore KF Confession 1:

We confess that we have worshipped and served an Idol Self that we have created.

You might wonder why, in KF, I decided to change the language of familiar Bible translations and introduce a vocabulary that may seem strange to some of you. This is an important question and one that I hope you are asking! Let's look at some of the thinking behind this decision to retranslate.

If you have grown up in the church, you will have heard certain words repeated over and over again, and you will have learned their theological definitions. Your mind goes on autopilot when you see or hear these familiar words and also the verses in which they appear. You believe that you already know what it all means. The Bible is a rich text that illustrates how the neurotic pride of the Idol Self militates against the True Self, the person God created you to be. Our goal in Karis Fellowships is to dismantle this Idol Self and reorient to our True Self and to God. With this goal in mind, I have retranslated Bible passages from the original Greek using vocabulary that highlights what the Scriptures say about the Idol Self and the redemption of our True Self. This new vocabulary helps us understand the working out of our salvation in Jesus as a process of reorientation.² I hope that these retranslations will give you a fresh vision of your true potential in Christ.

Reading Scripture or any ancient text in translation presents many obstacles to understanding. As anyone who speaks more than one language will know, it is often impossible to replace a single word with another single word without any loss of meaning. That's why, at times, I have chosen to paraphrase the original text rather than offer a direct translation. Then there is the question of the cultural context of a particular word or phrase. For example, the word *karis* should be considered in its Greco-Roman context if we are to fully grasp its meaning. It is important to remember, however, that Karis Fellowships is not a church or a theological seminary; it is simply a gathering of believers who are seeking to reorient to the glory that God originally designed for His creatures.

Here is an example of our unique vocabulary. In the NHG book study, we learned that the idealized self has the characteristics of the idols, or graven images, described in the Bible. Both the words *idol* and *ideal* come from the Greek word for an *imagined thing*. So, in KF, we call the idealized self by a more reprehensible and, I believe, a more accurate name—the Idol Self. Through Karis Fellowships training, we learn how to stop investing in this Idol Self and grow into our True Self, the only self that can express God's love. This isn't the love that we see in movies or read about in books. Rather, it is a precisely defined set of attributes and choices found in chapter 13 of Paul's first letter to the Corinthians.³

You really cannot recover your True Self without help. That's why we created Karis Fellowships. The KF training program is designed to be a one-year effort toward recovery, but many of us continue to train together year after year. We recognize the tendency to slip back into idolatry, especially when faced with new challenges and opportunities. We are not so very different from the Old Testament nations that resisted the discomforts of personal development and then, when afraid or euphoric, turned back to their idols.

Regularly review the **Love or Pride?** list. Compare your choices and behaviors with the items on that list and record them on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. When you are acting out of pride, you are often in fear. So, this week, under question two on your guide, record whatever triggered your fear and how you tried to defend your pride.

The book *The Art of Victory* gives us our KF motto, *Train hard. Fight easy.*⁴ (*Repeat the motto*) In KF, we learn to train hard. That isn't always fun, but we train hard so that we are able to fight easy when we find ourselves up against the Idol Self, spiritual opposition, or fear—not only in ourselves but in others. Without training you cannot fight your Idol; in adversity you will succumb to its demands. With training,

however, you will have the skills to overcome. You will be able to fight easy and be more than conquerors through Christ Jesus—and that’s exciting!⁵

Our prayer might go something like this:

Captain of the hosts, teach me to train hard that I might fight easy. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Now let’s look at John’s first letter, toward the back of the New Testament. This is my translation of **1 John 4:16–19**.

¹⁶We have come to know and have trusted the love which God has in us. God is love, and the one who dwells in love dwells in God, and God dwells in that one. ¹⁷By this, love is perfected with us, so that we may have boldness in the day of judgment, because as He is, so also are we in this world. ¹⁸There is no fear in love, but perfect love casts out fear, because fear involves punishment or torment, and the one who fears is not perfected in love. ¹⁹We love because He first extended love to us.

Take a deep breath.

1. Agape love, when oriented, is God’s love expressed through our lives

We learn in John’s Gospel that without Jesus we love—that is, we agape— darkness.⁶ This misoriented agape is generated within our Idol Self. We love darkness because it hides what we hate about ourselves. We hate the light because it will reveal the truth about who we are. Our poor Idol Self cannot love others or God because it is constantly reacting to outside threats and fiercely defending its ego, its stories, and its pride. It can feel great fondness, affection, and even obsession for whoever or whatever supports its claims and pride, but that is not oriented agape love.

Oriented agape love is responsive not reactive; it is not swayed by circumstances, nor is it determined by the merits of the one who is loved. This love is generated within the redeemed True Self through its correspondence, or co-responding, with God. It only exists in our world because someone has done the hard work necessary to become the love of God on earth. So, this love is really about your character and your connection to God. We have been created in God’s image; therefore, each one of us is uniquely designed to express His love. When you express God’s love through who you are and how you live, you display to the world both your Creator’s glory and your own.

2. The meaning of perfect

Now that we are looking closely at these verses in First John, it’s important to clarify the meaning of the word *perfect*, which is repeated several times in this passage. When we read the word perfect in English versions of the New Testament, we get the feeling that nothing is valuable unless it meets a certain standard. We must act perfectly, look perfect, think perfect thoughts, and, in this case, love perfectly—otherwise, all our efforts have no value. There is no invitation for growth or training. If you

have been raised this way, you know how painful and destructive it is. Anything less than perfect is judged as worthless.

However, these idealized standards of perfection are not what John is talking about. The word perfect is a translation of the Greek word *telos*, meaning the fulfillment of an intention or design. We could also translate *telos* using words like mature, accomplished, fulfilled, or fully developed. When John talks about a perfect love, he is referring to a love that is fully developed; it is fulfilling its purpose, and that purpose is to cast out fear. When your love starts casting out fear, you will know that your love is perfect—it is doing its job.

3. People of no fear

The Apostle John writes, “We have come to know and have trusted the love that God has in us.”⁷ What does it mean to come to know and trust the love that God has in us? Human beings have been afraid ever since Adam and Eve disconnected from God in the Garden, so we are used to motivating ourselves with fear. God designed us, however, to be motivated by love and not by fear, but it is difficult for us to make that transition. When we rely on the work of Jesus through the cross, we can begin to cooperate with God and allow His love to become our natural motivation. Just as money is deposited in a bank, God has deposited His love in us through the Holy Spirit. When we start to draw on that deposit and make it work in our lives, we discover what this love can do for us. We learn to trust it. The more we and our community experience this love, the more we all, together, gain confidence in its power. Our job in this world is to find our way back to love and let go of fear.

In verse 18 we read, “There is no fear in love; but developed love casts out fear, because fear involves punishment or torment, and the one who fears is not fully developed in love.” Our tendency is to focus on fighting our fears in order to avoid the torment, but John and God would have us focus on growing our love. As your love grows, your fears will automatically lose their power, and you will experience more freedom. Your goal is not to get rid of your fears; your goal is to grow your love.

As we live love and trust love, our love fulfills its purpose and frees us from fear. The Idol enslaves us through the fear of punishment, so we might equally say that love liberates us from the Idol Self. The Greek word for punishment can be translated as torment. The torment that we fear is our self-hate. Self-hate not only torments us but also everyone around us, but the love of God within us casts out the fear of torment and the torment of fear. The strength and support that this love provides empowers our True Self to successfully manage those inevitable moments when we are tormented by self-hate. The more we experience the love of God, the more we can trust that love, and the easier it will be to deal productively with our own self-hate and help others deal with theirs.

When my husband and I were trying to sell a house that had fallen in value by fifty-seven percent, I felt abject terror. I imagined that, for the rest of our lives, we would be bound to debt that would drain away the money we needed for current health care and for our retirement. The fear carried with it the torment of self-hate. I thought, “Why did I allow this to happen? I am such an idiot. We have ruined our lives.” Then, in the midst of this torment, I realized that I was focusing on the fear. I had been praying, “Lord, save us!” Now I started praying, “Lord, give our buyers the house that they love. Give our realtor the commission that she deserves. Move this house off the desk of the mortgage lenders and give them closure. Occupy this house for the good of the neighborhood.” When I began praying with love, my fear literally melted away. I had put my confidence in the love, and that stopped the torment. Yes, the house sold, miraculously, but the real miracle was learning to know and trust the love.

4. Learn to spot the fear

When you are punishing yourself, or punishing someone else, know that fear is motivating you. You are afraid of losing the life that you imagine will keep you safe and happy. When you feel the self-hate of the Idol whipping you from within, stop and tell yourself: *I feel really crummy right now. That's a good thing because it tells me where I need to learn to love. I am going to learn to love. I may not have it all figured out right now, but I know that listening to my self-hate is not what will help me or anyone else. I will figure out how to love with the help of Karis Fellowships, and I will be patient with myself while I learn. Fear is not my friend. Love is the foundation from which I will deal with self-hate.* Have that conversation with yourself and then tell your Idol Self to back off.

So, think about this: your Idol Self is motivated by fear; your True Self is motivated by love—and you are learning to recognize the difference.

During the week, try to spend some of your devotional time thinking about this teaching. You might carry the Bible passage with you on your phone or on a notecard.

You can take this lesson's Bible passage from First John and turn it into a prayer. In fact, let's do that right now. *(Pause)*

Lord, lead me to know and trust Your love. Teach me how to dwell in Your love. Mature Your love in me that I may be a person of no fear. (Repeat the last sentence)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

At these meetings, always try to have some purified water available and be prepared to take some notes. You might like to use the back of your **Meeting Preparation Guide**, or perhaps you have started a KF journal. Assume a mindfulness posture, follow my guidance, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider learning to really love. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider learning to really love*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. Feelings can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently allow whatever you are experiencing to remain in your awareness. We often flush thoughts and feelings from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Practice holding those thoughts and feelings in your awareness as you *consider learning to really love*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts

are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider learning to really love*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what hopelessness or frustration feels like in your body. Perhaps you feel trust or joy. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider learning to really love*. Does the idea of real love feel pleasant, scary, or vague and slippery? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge your present capacity to love as good or bad? *(Pause)* What do you believe about that? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—perhaps of yourself, of loss, or of others? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created you to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you do when they have *considered learning to really love*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with that information. *(Pause)* When fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for the whole human race as you learn to really love. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath and pause.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are grateful for this time together to train and heal. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth about ourselves. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

During the last lesson we mentioned the **KF Compass**, which regularly delivers portions of the **Expanded Version** to your inbox. If you would like to receive these emails, write to admin. Try it and see if it works for you. You can cancel at any time.

If you are the Karis Link of a new member, be sure to check in with them and ask how they are doing in KF.

¹ Zindel Segal, J. Mark G. Williams and John D. Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² Phil. 2:12.

³ 1 Cor. 13:1–13.

⁴ en.wikiquote.org/wiki/Alexander_Suvorov.

⁵ Rom. 8:37.

⁶ John 3:19.

⁷ 1 John 4:16.